

Mozilla Smartphones are Here to Replace Feature Phones!

After a long wait, Mozilla has finally launched Firefox-based smartphones in India. Coming from companies like Spice and Intex, Mozilla's devices are affordable and appeal to the entry-level smartphone users. The company plans to compete in this space only, and aims to offer an experience with a difference. **Diksha P Gupta** from **Open Source For You** spoke to **Dr James Ho**, senior director of mobile devices, Mozilla, about the company's strategy in India and how it plans to work with developers to make the Mozilla OS an even more robust system.



Dr James Ho, senior director of mobile devices, Mozilla

Q Don't you think you are late by over a year in bringing the Mozilla phone to India? Android is doing pretty well and with the launch of Android One, we have another ecosystem to look forward to. Android is well accepted in all price ranges and today, one can get an Android phone that is not clunky yet has a great user experience at a price that is equivalent to Mozilla's offering. So, how do you plan to position the Mozilla phone in this market?

I think to make a product successful, it is very important to meet the consumers' expectations. I think we took our time to understand what the users' aspirations are and what they are really looking for from their smartphones. We were able to take those aspirations into account. Frankly speaking, I

think it is never too late because it is a huge industry and is evolving so fast that whenever you come with the right product, you can connect with the consumers.

Q Firefox OS was first showcased two years ago at CES and you claimed to be bringing out a US\$ 25 phone at that point in time. Over the past two years, you have a footprint in over 17 countries. Are you satisfied with your performance so far?

We have seen some fabulous responses in the 17 countries that we are present in. We have seen people accepting the Mozilla ecosystem and being a part of its growth. We hope to see the same response in India as well. We are looking forward to expanding our horizons in more countries in the near future. We are also looking forward to launching Mozilla smartphones with more partners in the coming months.

Q In the price category that Mozilla's phones are available in, who is your prospective customer? Is it the people who are switching from feature phones to smartphones? Yes, from our perspective, most of the people picking up the Mozilla phones will be those switching from feature phones to smartphones. At the affordable price point where Mozilla devices are available, most people would want to upgrade from feature phones to a smartphone experience. The cheapest Android phone available in India right now is for Rs 3,000, which is a good 35 per cent higher than Mozilla's phone from Spice. That particular price segment is extremely price sensitive, and comprises the largest chunk of people who will pick up this phone. Having said that, I think smartphone users who are upset that their OSs are not upgraded would also want to try their hands on a Mozilla device. We believe that the Firefox OS, which is coming at this price point, will probably offer a little better experience for such users, who get a stale version of Android at this price point. This device will offer a better seamless experience to those who are already owners of a smartphone.